severe blows to his chest and Prem Dutt gave the magistrate graphic details of how the day before the police had inserted their fingers into their rectum and kicked them in the testicles. They asked the magistrate whether this was ‘civilization’ and warned him that the time would come when they would turn into ‘revolutionaries’.[5] A concerned government lawyer, Carden Noad, asked the magistrate to make a note of this threat. Bhagat Singh wanted to know of Rai Sahib Pandit Sri Kishen whether the police were acting on his orders. He did not answer. Bhagat Singh asked to have his manacles removed in court as he wanted to make a statement. The magistrate denied him this request. Only when the accused were taken to lunch was one handcuff removed from one hand. On 24 October 1929 it was agreed that the accused would now all come to court with handcuffs on only one hand.

The second occasion when the accused were subject to a brutal assault was even more serious. It happened before the special tribunal on 12 May 1930 after Bhagat Singh and the accused had walked into the courtroom. As the three tribunal judges prepared to commence the proceedings and the accused had their handcuffs removed, they began to sing their revolutionary song. This was not unusual. It was a standard feature of political trials in India. The practice was followed as a mark of defiance at the start of the trial. Judges had learnt to accommodate this because these songs were always before the proceedings began in revolutionary trials. The prisoners sang their songs to boost their morale. On this occasion, however, before they raised the cry of ‘Inquilab Zindabad’, a disgruntled Justice Coldstream (President) stamped his foot to their great surprise and announced that he would have none of this. The accused, he ordered, should have their handcuffs put on them again and that they be despatched back to their prison cells. Bhagat Singh objected. He refused to be manacled again. He insisted on his right to sing his song before the business of the day commenced. In this, he was only asking for what had already been accorded to him and his fellow prisoners, because from the very first day of the special tribunal hearings on 5 May 1930, they had all been allowed to sing their song. Their handcuffs were still on them. The court was not in session yet. There was no interference with proceedings. On each of the previous